

A grid of fast-rotating, chemically-homogeneous, supernova and/or long-GRB progenitors

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ABSTRACT

The understanding of stellar collapse and explosion has rapidly matured in recent years, and uncertainties in the progenitor profile at the onset of collapse are often dominant. We present a grid of 113 stellar models with initial masses $M_{\text{ZAMS}} = 30 - 90 M_{\odot}$ and initial rotation $\omega_{\text{ZAMS}}/\omega_{\text{crit}} = 0.5 - 0.99$ computed with MESA. We adopt a 128-isotope nuclear reaction network capable of self-consistently capture the weak reactions deleptonizing the core during and after silicon core burning. By construction, these models experience rotationally-induced chemically-homogeneous evolution, and reach the onset of collapse core-collapse ($v_{\text{infall}} \lesssim -300 \text{ km s}^{-1}$) with sufficient rotation to form accretion disks on the proto-compact object. Therefore, these progenitor structures provide a homogeneous playground with updated input physics and improved algorithmic accuracy to understand possibly-jetted stellar explosions, and long gamma ray bursts specifically.

Keywords: High Energy astrophysics (739) — Stellar astronomy (1583) —

1. INTRODUCTION

Understanding how massive stars’ iron cores collapse and, at least in some cases, the collapse successfully reverts into an explosion is a long-standing problem of astrophysics since the connection between massive-star populations and supernovae (W. Baade & F. Zwicky 1934). In the past $\sim$ century, the increased cadence, wavelength coverage, and depth of time-domain astronomy has lead to variations on this theme motivated by all kinds of astronomical transients (e.g., Z. Cano et al. 2017).

The core structure of a stellar progenitor determines the initial conditions for expensive multi-dimensional, multi-physics, (and often multi-million-CPUh) simulations. Specifically, the profile (of density, entropy, velocity, angular momentum, magnetic fields, etc., as a function of Lagrangian mass coordinate or radius) determines the dynamics of the infalling gas, and the “over-burden” encountered by a putative nascent outflow. Therefore, ultimately, it is the structure of the progenitor that determines whether a stellar model explodes or not, separately, whether it leaves behind a neutron star (NS) or a black hole (BH), and the properties of both the outflows, associated transients, and remnant (e.g., H.-T. Janka 2012; A. Burrows et al. 2024; O. Gotlieb et al. 2025).

Recent progress in core-collapse supernova (SN) theory has produce unprecedented agreement among groups performing numerical simulations of neutrino-radiative transfer (e.g., H.-T. Janka 2012; C. D. Ott et al. 2018; D. Vartanyan et al. 2019; A. Burrows et al. 2025; K. Nakamura et al. 2025). While the impact of ingredients other than neutrino heating remains debated (e.g., N. Soker 2024), a consensus on the fact that uncertainties in the stellar progenitor structure are dominant is emerging (e.g., T. Sukhbold & S. E. Woosley 2016; M. Limongi & A. Chieffi 2018; L. Boccioli & L. Roberti 2024; A. Burrows et al. 2025; A. Griffiths et al. 2026).

The capability to study the origin of transients and compact objects is ever more important in the era of large time-domain surveys (e.g., Rubin/LSST, Ž. Ivezić et al. 2019) and routine detections of gravitational-wave mergers (e.g., A. G. Abac et al. 2025; The LIGO Scientific Collaboration et al. 2026). The current bottleneck in these studies is the availability of models of stellar progenitors computed *i* sufficiently late into the collapse and *ii* including sufficient physics to capture the known critical ingredients for the explosion.

Specifically, point *i* requires pushing the stellar evolution models well into the sub-sonic phase of the collapse, at least beyond when timescales associated to stellar processes are longer than the remaining time to core-bounce. This typically means evolving beyond iron-core infall velocity $v_{\text{infall}} = \min(v) \lesssim -300 \text{ km s}^{-1}$

(e.g., R. Farmer et al. 2023; O. Gottlieb et al. 2024) if not -1000 km s^{-1} (e.g., S. E. Woosley 2002). Beyond this point, matter typically becomes partially optically thick to neutrinos, and the thermodynamics exceeds the bounds of tabulated equations of state in stellar evolution codes.

For point *ii*, a stellar model to be used to understand the explosion physics needs to be as accurate as possible in its density and angular momentum profile. Any star evolving through silicon core burning will experience copious amounts of electron captures (e.g., W. D. Arnett 1977; W. R. Hix & F.-K. Thielemann 1993, 1999; A. Grichener et al. 2025) which progressively de-leptonize the core (i.e., decrease the amount of free electrons). These occur at a significant rate even in the late hydrostatic stellar evolution, and before a model is sufficiently evolved by the criterion *i*. The notable exceptions to this are “electron-capture” SN progenitors which collapse with a ONeMg-rich core (however, these too require appropriate treatment of the weak reactions, including URCA processes, K. Nomoto 1984; K. Takahashi et al. 2013) and progenitors above the pair-instability gap (e.g., G. Rakavy & G. Shaviv 1967; S. E. Woosley 2017; M. Renzo et al. 2024) which collapse because of the photodisintegration instability in an oxygen-rich core (e.g., J. R. Bond 1984; O. Gottlieb et al. 2025).

To decrease the computing time and number of models stopped by numerical issues in a grid of stellar progenitors, a commonly adopted shortcut is to use small (~ 20 -isotope) nuclear reaction networks (e.g., O. R. Pols et al. 1995; F. X. Timmes et al. 2000). These bypass the complex nuclear physics of silicon core burning by lumping all weak interactions in a custom compound reaction (see A. Grichener et al. 2025), effectively sacrificing the accuracy of the core structure that decides the explosion. Even if such compound reaction is tuned on the central value of the electron fraction Y_e from models with more accurate nuclear reaction networks (e.g., D. R. Aguilera-Dena et al. 2018; F. R. N. Schneider et al. 2021, 2024), small networks cannot predict the *profile* $Y_e(m)$ of the collapsing core in the region where the explosions are decided. While this is an acceptable trade-off to study, for example, electromagnetic observables determined at the surface (e.g., V. Morozova et al. 2015), it is not sufficient if one want to investigate the driving of the explosions, the pre-explosions and explosive neutrino signals, the nuclear yields, and the resulting compact object properties (whether considering non-rotating – R. Farmer et al. 2016 – or rotating progenitors – M. Renzo et al. 2024). The reason is that the effective Chandrasekhar mass of the collapsing core scales with $\propto Y_e^2$, or in other words, the contribution of electron-degeneracy-pressure to the

support of the core amplifies small imprecision in the core structure to a level significant for the collapse and explosion dynamics.

Few grids of stellar progenitors evolved sufficiently late (*i*) and with *detailed* nuclear physics (*ii*) exist, mostly from closed-source codes (e.g., KEPLER T. A. Weaver et al. 1978; S. E. Woosley 2002; S. E. Woosley & A. Heger 2006; S. E. Woosley 2007; T. Sukhbold & S. E. Woosley 2016; T. Sukhbold et al. 2018, FRANEC³ M. Limongi & A. Chieffi 2003, 2018, HOSHI, K. Takahashi et al. 2013). While these stellar models have been invaluable in allowing the progress made so far, they do not allow to explore the sensitivity of the results to *physical* and *numerical* choices in the evolution of the progenitors, that have been shown to influence the core structure and thus explosion outcomes (e.g., R. Farmer et al. 2016; M. Renzo et al. 2017; A. Davis et al. 2019; E. Laplace et al. 2021; K. Maltsev et al. 2025; M. A. Myers et al. 2026).

A few public grids of progenitors fulfilling both conditions *i* and *ii* computed with the open-source and community-driven code MESA exist (e.g., R. Farmer et al. 2016; M. Renzo et al. 2017; E. Laplace et al. 2021; E. Farag et al. 2020; R. Farmer et al. 2023; M. A. Myers et al. 2026). These have largely been under-utilized for initializing explosion simulations (see however D. Vartanyan et al. 2021). Even fewer open-source models of rotating progenitors exist, despite their importance for jetted explosions, collapsars, MHD-explosions, and/or long γ -ray burst (IGRB, S. E. Woosley 1993; A. I. MacFadyen & S. E. Woosley 1999; O. Gottlieb 2025).

The reason for this bottleneck is the significant computational cost of evolved massive stars with the necessary large nuclear-reaction networks (neglecting the sparsity, the size of the matrix to solve scales with $\sim N^2$ with N number of isotopes), coupled with the stiffness of the equations (see A. Grichener et al. 2025), which results in large fractions of progenitor grids failing before reaching the desired infall velocity.

Development of numerical strategies to address these issues are ongoing. In the meantime, we present here a publicly-available grid of fast-rotating models fulfilling both criteria (*i*, “late enough”) and (*ii*, “including enough nuclear physics to accurately simulate the structure”) for studies of the collapse and possible explosion of fast rotating stellar cores.

In Sec. 2 we describe the physical assumptions and numerical setup. Sec. 3 presents the computed grid, and

³ which does not include hydrodynamics and thus cannot reach condition *i* (e.g., E. O’Connor & C. D. Ott 2010; M. Limongi & A. Chieffi 2020).

we contextualize our result in terms of the input and code physics in Sec. 4.2. In Sec. 4.1 we briefly outline the astrophysical scenarios that could be approximated with our models. Finally, we conclude in Sec. 5. Appendix A lists some key quantities for the “explodability” and surface composition at the onset of collapse, and Appendix B describes in detail the publicly available input and output files of our simulations, available at doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.14286306.

2. NUMERICAL SETUP

The grid of models presented here is an extension of (and includes) the progenitor star used in O. Gottlieb et al. (2024) and constitutes the input for the “averaged” progenitor constructed in H.-S. Chan et al. (2026). We use the MESA code (version r24.03.1, B. Paxton et al. 2011, 2013, 2015, 2016, 2019; A. S. Jermyn et al. 2023), to compute low-metallicity ($Z = 0.001$) and fast-rotating stellar models. Our grid spans initial masses $M_{\text{ZAMS}} = 30 - 90 M_{\odot}$ and initial (rigid) rotation with angular frequency $\omega_{\text{ZAMS}}/\omega_{\text{crit}} = 0.5 - 0.99$, where $\omega_{\text{crit}} = \sqrt{(1 - L/L_{\text{Edd}})GM/R^3}$ is the surface critical rotation rate accounting for radiative forces, L is the stellar luminosity, L_{Edd} the Eddington luminosity, G is the gravitational constant, M is the total mass and R the stellar radius.

We use the SKYE equation of state (A. S. Jermyn et al. 2021), and include electron screening following A. I. Chugunov et al. (2007) and thermal neutrino losses following N. Itoh et al. (1996). In our setup, radiative opacities are primarily from OPAL (C. A. Iglesias & F. J. Rogers 1993, 1996) and electron conduction opacities are from S. Cassisi et al. (2007).

We adopt nuclear reaction rates that are a combination of NACRE (C. Angulo et al. 1999), JINA REACLIB (R. H. Cyburt et al. 2010), and $^{12}\text{C}(\alpha, \gamma)^{16}\text{O}$ from R. Kunz et al. (2002), plus additional tabulated weak reaction rates G. M. Fuller et al. (1985); T. Oda et al. (1994); K. Langanke & G. Martínez-Pinedo (2000). To capture with sufficient accuracy the deleptonization of the core from the structural point of view (condition *ii* in Sec. 1), we adopt the fully-coupled 128-isotope nuclear reaction network `mesa_128.net` (R. Farmer et al. 2016; A. Grichener et al. 2025). For central temperatures above $\log_{10}(T) \geq 9.2$, we employ MESA in operator split mode (A. S. Jermyn et al. 2023).

Throughout the evolution, we include the wind mass loss rate following J. Vink et al. (2000) and T. Nugis & H. J. G. L. M. Lamers (2000) for surface ^4He mass fraction $Y_{\text{surf}} \geq 0.4$, assuming the metallicity scaling from J. S. Vink et al. (2001) and the rotational enhancement

from D. B. Friend & D. C. Abbott (1986) (see also N. Langer 1998).

We use the Schwarzschild criterion and the L. Henyey et al. (1965) formulation of mixing-length theory for convective layers, with $\alpha_{\text{MLT}} = 1.5$. For convective boundary mixing, we include core overshooting as a step-function following I. Brott et al. (2011) ($\alpha_{\text{ov}} = 0.335$) and treat rotational mixing in diffusion approximation following A. Heger et al. (2000), including angular momentum transport by convection or by a “classical” Tayler-Spruit dynamo (H. C. Spruit 2002) in radiative regions. All the models presented here result by construction in a rotationally-driven chemically homogeneous evolution (CHE, e.g., A. Maeder & G. Meynet 2000; S.-C. Yoon et al. 2006).

After the formation of a carbon-oxygen core, we prevent the development of spurious numerical velocities in the outer layers by artificially setting to zero the velocity in any layer that has a sound-propagation time from the outer edge of the core, or the location where the specific entropy drops below $10.5 N_A k_B$, whichever is further in, longer than the current timestep. Similar artificial damping exists in most calculations of post-core-carbon burning massive stars (e.g., D. R. Aguilera-Dena et al. 2018).

To produce progenitors sufficiently close to core-bounce (condition *i* in Sec. 1), we evolve each model until the infall velocity in the iron core decreases below $v_{\text{infall}} \leq -300 \text{ km s}^{-1}$ (e.g., R. Farmer et al. 2023; O. Gottlieb et al. 2024). This threshold is motivated by the numerical experiments performed in O. Gottlieb et al. (2024) where we showed that the physical time remaining between this point and the canonical threshold of -1000 km s^{-1} is much shorter than the timescale governing the local evolution of the rotation and magnetic fields.

Numerical resolution should always be tested in stellar models (e.g., R. Farmer et al. 2016). We refer readers to the appendix of O. Gottlieb et al. (2024) for tests on the spatial and temporal resolution of these models performed with the same setup and code on the initially $40 M_{\odot}$ and $\omega = 0.6 \omega_{\text{crit}}$ model.

3. RESULTS

Our grid consists initially of 11 values of $\omega_{\text{ZAMS}}/\omega_{\text{crit}}$ per each of the 36 M_{ZAMS} values, for a total of 396 stellar models. Of these, 113 successfully reach the onset of core-collapse and pass our visual inspection to remove models experiencing large L and effective temperature (T_{eff}) excursions. These may be manifestations of physical processes in the envelope (e.g., A. Heger et al. 1997, for red-supergiant stars) and/or numerical arti-

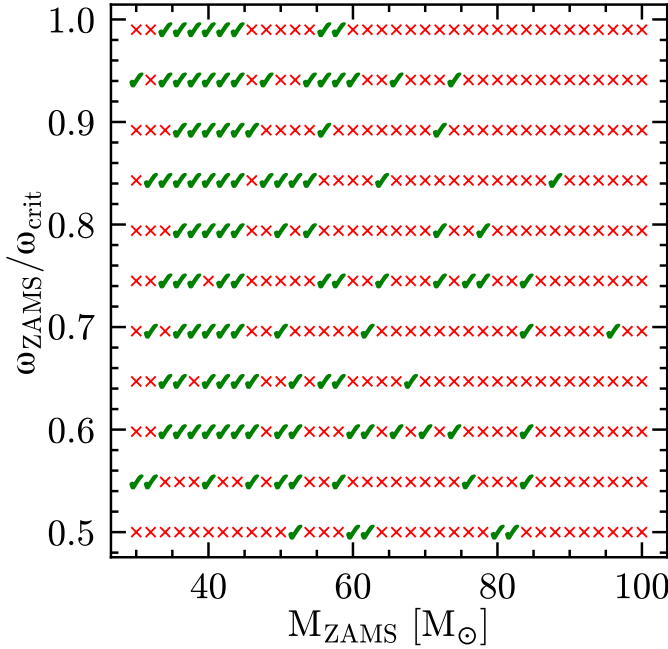


Figure 1. Overview of the grid success rate. Green check marks correspond to successful models. Red crosses correspond to models that either do not reach infall velocities of -300 km s^{-1} or they exhibit large luminosity and effective temperature excursions that are treated un-physically in our setup and can impact the core-structure.

facts amplified by the small timesteps necessary in late evolutionary phases (since the acceleration term in the momentum equation is calculated as $\Delta v/\Delta t$, it can become extremely large for small Δt). Our setup is not designed to properly capture physical phenomena in the outer envelopes this late in the evolution, and large L and T_{eff} can feedback on the core structure, motivating our choice to exclude these models from our grid. Overall, our grid has a 29% success rate, relatively high for models that are *not* manually mentored in any way.

As shown in Fig. 1, successful models in our grid sample relatively uniformly the parameter space $30 M_{\odot} \lesssim M_{\text{ZAMS}} \lesssim 60 M_{\odot}$ across all rotation rates explored ($0.5 \lesssim \omega_{\text{ZAMS}}/\omega_{\text{crit}} \lesssim 0.99$), and the number of successes decrease at larger initial masses and rotation rates. However, there is no particular threshold beyond which models systematically fail: this suggests most failures come from numerical errors in the solution of the stiff equations describing late stellar evolution rather than physical hypothesis and/or their algorithmic representation.

From this point onward, we focus on the analysis of the successful models. Fig. 2 shows an overview of this grid, with each thin blue line corresponding to one star. The thick orange lines correspond to the model used as

progenitor in O. Gottlieb et al. (2024), highlighted to guide the eye.

The top left panel shows a Hertzsprung-Russell diagram, where models evolve from the bottom right towards the top left, as indicated by the arrow. Because of the large rotation imposed at birth, these models experience CHE (A. Maeder & G. Meynet 2000; S.-C. Yoon et al. 2006; S. E. de Mink et al. 2009). Rotational mixing (dominated by meridional circulations) prevents the formation of a chemical stratification and the emergence of a core/envelope boundary during the hydrogen-core burning main sequence. The entire star is enriched in ^4He (and ^{14}N at the expenses of ^{12}C and ^{16}O because of the CNO cycle, H. A. Bethe 1939), reducing the envelope opacity and preventing the red-ward evolution and radial expansion. Nevertheless, the increase in mean-molecular weight leads to an increase in luminosity (e.g., R. Kippenhahn et al. 2013; C. Xin et al. 2022).

At the end of the hydrogen-core burning main sequence, each track shows a characteristic “hook”: this corresponds to a thermal timescale phase of contraction because of the exhaustion of hydrogen in the entire core region, corresponding to most of the star in this CHE models.

Helium ignition in the center causes the star to briefly re-expand up to its maximum radius. Nevertheless, each star remains relatively small, with $\max(R) \lesssim 31 R_{\odot}$ and $T_{\text{eff}} \gtrsim 10^{4.5} \text{ K}$ across the entire grid. This minimizes the chances for binary mass-transfer with putative companions for CHE stars (e.g., S. E. de Mink et al. 2009). We emphasize that from this point onwards the evolution is not *homogeneous* anymore: while rotational mixing remains active, the evolutionary timescale speeds up significantly owing to the lower energy release per nucleon for heavier nuclear fuels, and chemical gradients seeded by the burning impede further mixing (e.g., A. Heger et al. 2000; S.-C. Yoon et al. 2006; A. Chieffi & M. Limongi 2013). The stars develop a distinct carbon-oxygen core, and a “onion”-like structure.

The remaining evolution occurs roughly right-to-left at constant luminosity, with wind mass-loss progressively removing mass, and revealing hotter inner layers of the star. The hottest point and smallest radius is reached roughly at core Neon ignition (O. Gottlieb et al. 2024), after which stars typically expand slightly again. We note that the majority of the models failing (red crosses in Fig. 1, excluded from Fig. 2 and beyond) occur during or after Neon core burning. This is because this burning phase occurs through photodisintegration $^{20}\text{Ne}(\gamma, \alpha)^{16}\text{O}$ which produces α particles which have extremely high reaction rates at the temperatures ($T \gtrsim 1.5 \times 10^9 \text{ K}$, R. Kippenhahn et al. 2013), and thus

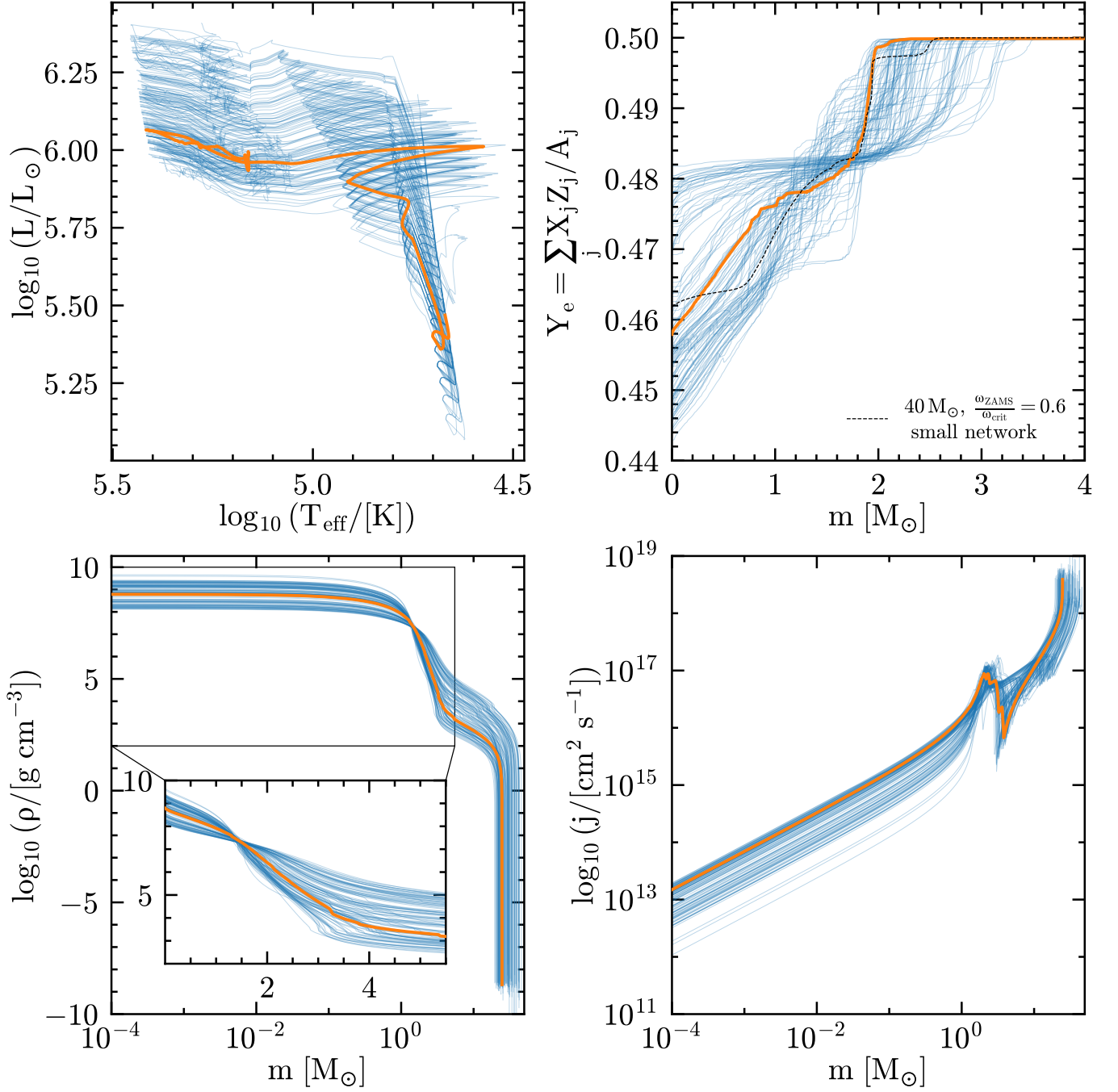


Figure 2. *Top left:* Hertzsprung-Russell diagram of rotationally-induced chemically-homogeneous evolving single star models. *Top right:* Inner electron fraction Y_e profile as a function of mass, the thin black dot-dashed line is the $40 M_{\odot}$, $\omega_{\text{ZAMS}} = 0.6 \omega_{\text{crit}}$ computed with a 22-isotope network from [M. Renzo et al. \(2024\)](#) available from [10.5281/zenodo.11375522](#). The vertical dashed line marks $m = 1.75 M_{\odot}$ used to calculate the compactness $\xi_{1.75}$. *Bottom left:* Density profiles as a function of Lagrangian mass coordinate m on a logarithmic scale. The inset zooms on the inner region and uses a linear scale. *Bottom right:* Specific angular momentum profiles as a function of m . In all panels, the orange thick line marks a representative $40 M_{\odot}$, $\omega_{\text{ZAMS}} = 0.6 \omega_{\text{crit}}$ used in [O. Gottlieb et al. \(2024\)](#).

the equations for the evolution of the core composition become significantly stiffer and numerically challenging.

The top right panel of Fig. 2 shows the profiles of the electron fraction $Y_e = \sum_j X_j Z_j / A_j$, where X_j is the mass fraction of the j -th isotope with charge $+Z_j e$ and atomic mass A_j , in the innermost $m \leq 4 M_\odot$ at the onset of core-collapse. Outside this mass coordinate $Y_e \simeq 0.5$, while inside, weak-reactions, treated explicitly in our nuclear reaction network, lead to deleptonization and lower the Y_e creating a profile consistent with the thermodynamical conditions in the evolving cores. We also show with a thin black dot-dashed line the $40 M_\odot$, $\omega_{\text{ZAMS}} = 0.6 \omega_{\text{crit}}$ model from M. Renzo et al. (2024) computed with a small 22-isotope network and an otherwise identical setup, for comparison with the thick solid orange line corresponding to the same initial conditions in our grid using a 128-isotope network. The difference between these two Y_e profiles is larger than the difference between models of varying mass and initial rotations: the systematic error from using a small nuclear reaction network biases conclusions on the connection between progenitors, explosions, and remnants (R. Farmer et al. 2016; M. Renzo et al. 2024).

In Fig. 2, the bottom left panel shows the full density profiles at the onset of collapse as a function of $\log_{10}(m/M_\odot)$, to focus on the inner layers of our CHE models. The inset panel shows the innermost $m < 5 M_\odot$ on a linear scale. The density profile $\rho(m)$ in these inner layers depends strongly on the $Y_e(m)$ because of the contribution of electron degeneracy pressure to the support of the core, and it determines the infall velocity profile once electron-captures (and later photodisintegration) remove pressure support (e.g., H.-T. Janka 2012). Moreover, the density determines the initial accretion onto the shock generated at core-bounce, and thus the neutrino luminosity (e.g. D. Vartanyan et al. 2021; A. Burrows et al. 2024). Finally, the density profile is also related to the angular momentum profile via the mass-continuity equation relating $\rho(m)$ and the radial distribution of mass $r(m)$.

The bottom right panel shows the specific angular momentum per unit mass $j = r^2 \omega$ at the onset of core-collapse. This can be compared to the angular momentum of the innermost stable circular orbit of a putative seed BH to decide whether a disk will form at collapse (e.g., A. I. MacFadyen & S. E. Woosley 1999; R. Perna et al. 2018), or whether a fast-spinning magnetar needs to form first (e.g., D. Kasen & L. Bildsten 2010; O. Gottlieb et al. 2024).

An alternative way to characterize the structure of our models at the onset of core collapse is to look at the specific entropy profiles s , presented in Fig. 3. Flat

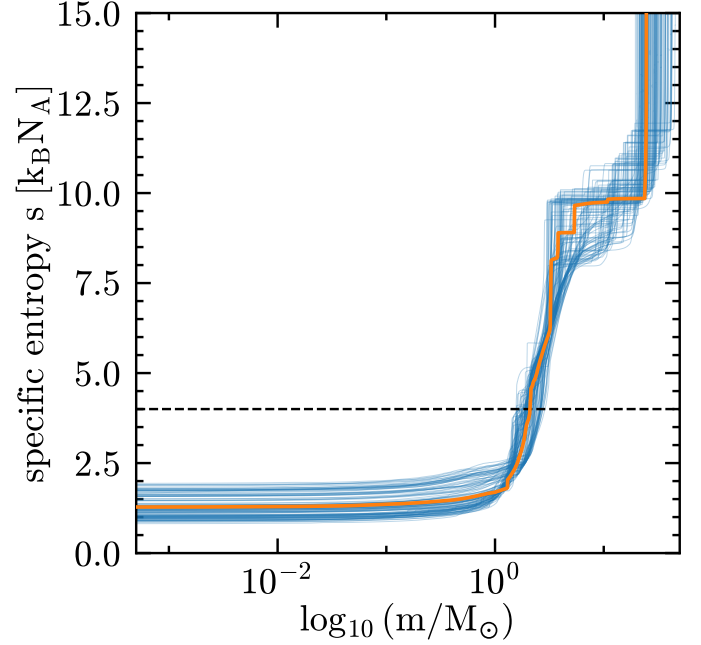


Figure 3. Specific entropy profiles. The dashed black horizontal line marks the $s = 4 k_B N_A$ location often used in “explodability” criteria (e.g., T. Ertl et al. 2016; T. Ertl et al. 2020). The orange thick line shows the $40 M_\odot$, $\omega_{\text{ZAMS}} = 0.6 \omega_{\text{crit}}$ model from O. Gottlieb et al. (2024).

“steps” correspond to stellar regions that experience *efficient* convection, resulting in a very-nearly adiabatic (i.e., constant s) profiles. The mass-location of these depends on the detailed evolution of each stellar model in our grid. Fig. 3 vertical axis is cut at $s = 15 k_B N_A$ to focus the visualization on the inner core where stellar explosions are decided, and thus excludes the outer (higher-entropy) layers of the stars.

The Tayler-Spruit dynamo responsible for angular momentum transport in radiative regions of our CHE models generates magnetic fields. Fig. 4 shows the azimuthal (B_ϕ , top) and the radial (B_r , bottom) components as a function of mass coordinate on a logarithmic scale at the onset of collapse. These magnetic fields are *local* and not large-scale coherently organized fields. We refer interested readers to O. Gottlieb et al. (2024) (Sec. 2.1) for more details and how to calculate the magnetic flux advected during the initial phases of a core collapse.

Fig. 5 shows the compactness parameter (E. O’Connor & C. D. Ott 2011):

$$\xi_{\mathcal{M}} = \frac{\mathcal{M}/M_\odot}{r(\mathcal{M})/1000 \text{ km}} \quad , \quad (1)$$

against the initial mass (M_{ZAMS} , top axis) and iron core mass (M_{Fe} , bottom axis), defined as the outermost location where the mass fraction $X(^{28}\text{Si}) < 0.1$ and $\sum_j X_j > 0.1$ where the sum runs over all species

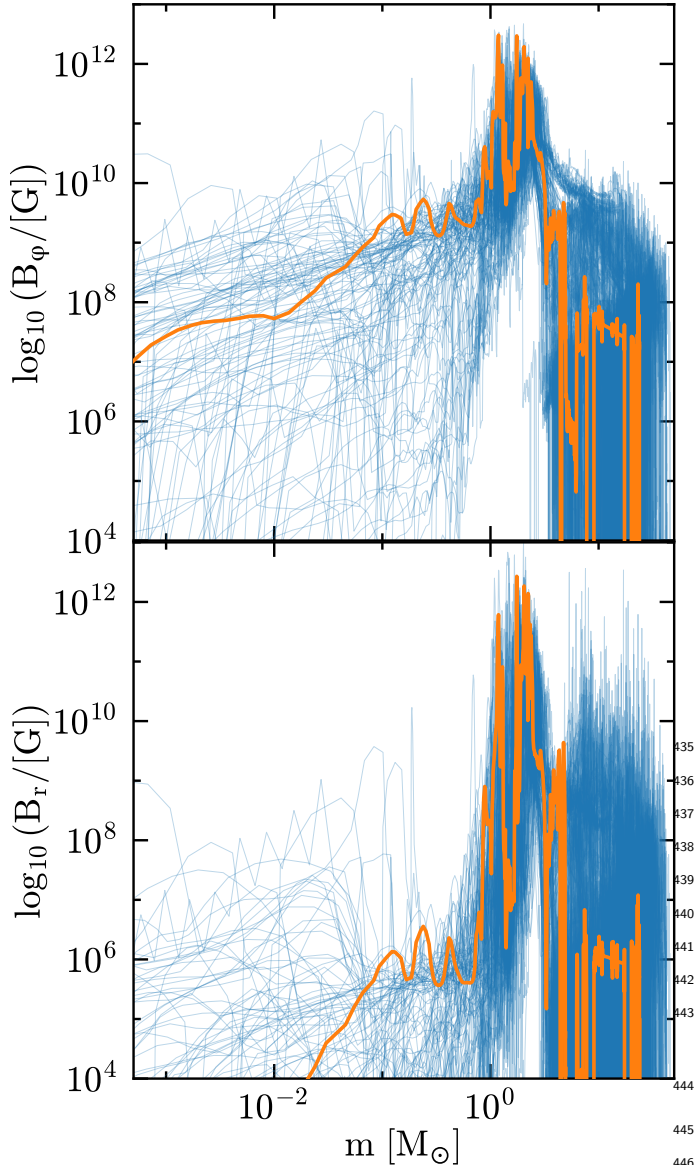


Figure 4. Azimuthal (top) and radial (bottom) component of the *local* magnetic field generated by the Spruit-Taylor dynamo as a function of Lagrangian mass coordinate. The orange thick line shows the $40M_{\odot}$, $\omega_{\text{ZAMS}} = 0.6\omega_{\text{crit}}$ model from O. Gottlieb et al. (2024).

with $A_j > 46$. We use $\mathcal{M} = 1.75 M_{\odot}$ to calculate the compactness following A. Burrows et al. (2024), highlighted also by the vertical black dashed line in the top right panel of Fig. 2. Large values of $\xi_{1.75}$ are more likely to result in BH formation, but this does not imply the collapse does not result in a successful explosion since the accretion rate on the shock, and consequently the neutrino luminosity thought to drive the shock correlate positively with $\xi_{1.75}$ (e.g., T. Kuroda et al. 2018; C. D. Ott et al. 2018; A. Burrows et al. 2025).

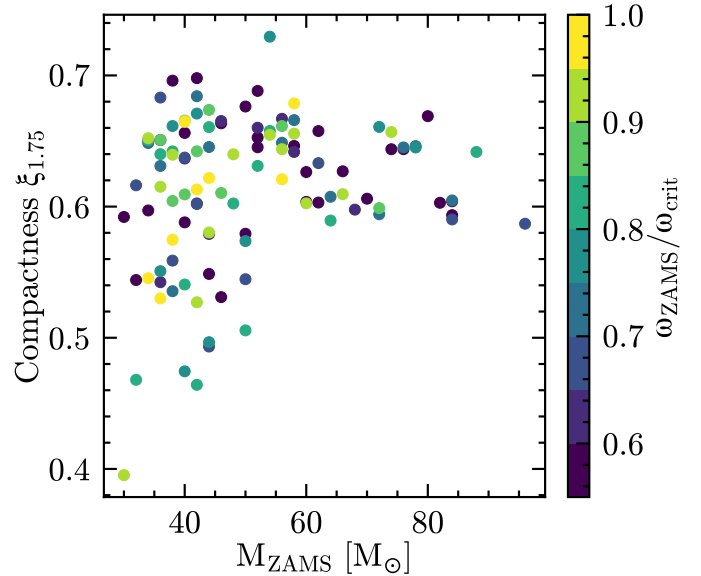


Figure 5. Compactness as a function initial mass and rotation rate for single CHE models. ■ make M_{ZAMS} top axis and M_{Fe} bottom axis ■

The colors in Fig. 5 indicate the initial rotation rate, and we see the typical correlation between iron core-mass and compactness found in non-rotating models (e.g., T. Sukhbold & S. E. Woosley 2016; M. Limongi & A. Chieffi 2018). Rotation introduces perturbations on this trend, and it appears that initially faster rotating models (darker points) tend to have a larger $\xi_{1.75}$, but this trend is not true at all masses – likely because of the high non-linearity of stellar evolution.

4. DISCUSSION

4.1. What astrophysical scenario can these model represent?

The existence of direct observational evidence (e.g., from stellar spectroscopy) for rotationally-induced chemically-homogeneous evolution is still debated, although this evolutionary path becomes more likely at very high stellar masses and low metallicities (e.g., S.-C. Yoon et al. 2006). To produce fast-rotating collapsar progenitors, we construct our stellar models at $Z = 0.001$ and *assuming* extremely fast initial rotation rates. These are prohibitively rare regardless of Z in young massive star populations the local Universe (e.g., I. Hunter et al. 2008; O. H. Ramírez-Agudelo et al. 2013; O. H. Ramírez-Agudelo et al. 2015; P. L. Dufton et al. 2019; D. Galán-Diéguez et al. 2026; D. J. Lennon et al. 2026). While there is growing evidence for relatively fast ($\gtrsim 250 \text{ km s}^{-1}$) primordial rotation (e.g., Y. Nazé et al. 2023; N. Britavskiy et al. 2024; Y. Nazé et al. 2025), these still have $\omega \lesssim 0.3 - 0.4\omega_{\text{crit}}$ and are not

as fast as we are assuming here. The fastest-rotating known O-type stars reach $v \sin(i) \sim 600 \text{ km s}^{-1}$, likely in the regime considered here, and are most likely accretor stars in interacting binaries (M. Cantiello et al. 2007; O. H. Ramírez-Agudelo et al. 2015; M. Renzo & Y. Götzberg 2021). The accretion process can change the core-envelope boundary in ways that are not accounted for in our single-star models (e.g., M. Cantiello et al. 2007; M. Renzo & Y. Götzberg 2021; M. Renzo et al. 2023; T. Wagg et al. 2024; N. Shah et al. 2026).

Nevertheless, the observation of jetted explosions and IGRBs suggest that somehow, some stars reach core collapse with sufficient angular momentum to form accretion disks onto a seed compact object. This could be the product of accretion on the secondary in an interacting binary system (e.g., M. Cantiello et al. 2007), stellar mergers retaining angular momentum (e.g., E. Chatzopoulos et al. 2020; M. Renzo et al. 2020), tidal spin up in post-common envelope massive binaries (S. S. Bavera et al. (2020, 2022); K. Sen et al. (2025)), or possibly inefficient angular momentum transport in stars, leading to spin up of the core as it evolves and contracts. We do not consider here the possibility of disk formation from stochastic angular momentum in extended convective envelopes (e.g., E. Quataert et al. 2019; D. Shishkin & N. Soker 2021; A. Antoni et al. 2025) because IGRBs are associated to type Ic broad-line SNe that require hydrogen-free progenitors with compact envelopes.

We do not attempt to investigate the detailed evolutionary scenarios leading to fast rotating cores. Instead, we provide a computationally homogeneous grid of single, initially fast-rotating stellar progenitors that could *approximate* these scenarios in the hope of enabling controlled numerical experiments for stellar collapse where rotation and magnetic field are expected to play a role.

4.2. Known physical and numerical caveats

The specific angular momentum profile of our models is a product of the assumed initial rotation and the interplay between wind-mass loss and angular momentum transport. We assumed a combination of J. Vink et al. (2000); J. S. Vink et al. (2001) and T. Nugis & H. J. G. L. M. Lamers (2000) for line-driven wind mass loss, as opposed to most previous grids of fast-rotating progenitors adopting a combination of H. Nieuwenhuijzen & C. de Jager (1990) (e.g., S. E. Woosley & A. Heger 2006) and W.-R. Hamann et al. (1995) (e.g., D. R. Aguilera-Dena et al. 2018, 2020). For angular momentum transport, we adopt a Tayler-Spruit dynamo in radiative regions (H. C. Spruit 2002). As noted in O. Gottlieb et al. (2024) based on the $40 M_{\odot}$ model with $\omega_{\text{ZAMS}} = 0.6 \omega_{\text{crit}}$ (orange line in Fig. 2-4), adopting the

stronger magnetic field saturation of the Tayler-Spruit instability suggested in J. Fuller et al. (2019); J. Fuller & W. Lu (2022) results in slowly-rotating cores at collapse that do not produce accretion disks. All these processes are highly uncertain in stellar context (see, e.g., N. Smith 2014; M. Renzo et al. 2017; A. Romagnolo et al. 2026 for wind-related uncertainties, H. C. Spruit 1999; M. Cantiello et al. 2014; J. Fuller et al. 2019; J. W. den Hartogh et al. 2020; V. A. Skoutnev & A. M. Beloborodov 2024, 2025 for angular momentum transport uncertainties), and active topics of research.

The 128-isotope nuclear reaction network we adopt is sufficient to resolve the density structure of the core. Increasing further the network size has negligible impact on the electron fraction Y_e . This has been shown both with full stellar models calculations (e.g., R. Farmer et al. 2016) and focused one-zone experiments (e.g., A. Grichener et al. 2025). We note however that the list of isotopes adopted here may still under-resolve the precollapse neutrino flux (e.g., E. Farag et al. 2020) and may not be suitable for detailed nucleosynthesis studies (e.g., M. A. Myers et al. 2026).

Moreover, the nuclear reaction rates adopted (specifically the $^{12}\text{C}(\alpha, \gamma)^{16}\text{O}$ from R. Kunz et al. 2002) are under active scrutiny in the community (e.g., R. J. deBoer et al. 2017; K. Takahashi 2018; R. Farmer et al. 2019; G. Costa et al. 2021; Y. Shen et al. 2023; A. Noll et al. 2025; H. Tong et al. 2026) and our choice certainly influences the pre-collapse structures presented here (like any other stellar models in the literature).

As any set of stellar evolution calculations, the representation of the inherently three-dimensional convective flow (e.g., A. S. Jermyn et al. 2022; M. Joyce & J. Tayar 2023) and convective boundaries (e.g., A. Davis et al. 2019; M. A. Myers et al. 2026) are potential causes of concern. The key hypothesis of subsonic flows holds throughout the evolution of our models. However, our choice of free parameters (α_{MLT} and α_{ov}) to match existing literature (e.g., I. Brott et al. 2011; D. R. Aguilera-Dena et al. 2018, 2020) may not be appropriate for every convective layer in the stars (e.g., A. Griffiths et al. 2026), and does not include the latest updates from stellar hydrodynamics simulations (e.g. E. H. Anders et al. 2022; F. Rizzuti et al. 2023; C. Johnston et al. 2024).

Maybe more importantly, our models adopt an artificial strategy to expunge envelope velocities in the outer layers, possibly seeded by numerical noise in the fast-paced late burning evolution. Significant efforts to improve MESA to address these is ongoing.

Despite these inevitable caveats when producing numerical models relying on input physics and physical processes under active investigation, our models provide

a significant update in the context of fast-rotating CHE stars evolved until the onset of core-collapse.

5. CONCLUSION

We presented a grid of rotationally-driven chemically-homogeneously evolving massive stars at the onset of core-collapse. We have described their evolution on the Hertzsprung-Russel diagram and characterized their internal profiles at the onset of core-collapse, and discussed physical and numerical limitations of our calculations.

The evolution of these initially fast-rotating models represents directly a presumably extremely rare evolutionary path based on observations of initial rotation rates in the local Universe and rates of astrophysical transients, and could approximate to a certain degree more common evolutionary paths where rotation is produced, for example, by binary interactions. Further studies to compare the outcome of these pathways with single-fast rotating models are necessary.

Despite the inevitable algorithmic and input physics limitations inherent in numerical models (especially of astrophysical systems represented by very stiff sets of equations), our models constitutes a significant update

in input physics and numerical accuracy for fast-rotating collapsing stellar progenitors. We hope that our publicly available results (at doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.14286306) will be adopted for numerical experiments in studying the explosions of rotating massive stars.

Software: This study made use of the following software packages: MESA (B. Paxton et al. 2011, 2013, 2015, 2019; A. S. Jermyn et al. 2023), python (G. Van Rossum & F. L. Drake 2009), numpy (C. R. Harris et al. 2020), and matplotlib (J. D. Hunter 2007). Software citation information aggregated using The Software Citation Station (T. Wagg & F. S. Broekgaarden 2024; T. Wagg et al. 2025).

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APPENDIX

A. EXPLODABILITY METRICS AND SURFACE COMPOSITION

Tab. 1 lists for each successful model in our grid a few key quantities related to their “explodability” and their surface composition. Specifically, we list $\xi_{1.75}$ and M_{Fe} shown also in Fig. 5, M_4 is the outermost mass coordinate where the specific entropy is $s = 4 k_B N_A$ and the mass-gradient at that location μ_4 , which together can be combined in the two-parameter explodability criterion by T. Ertl et al. (2016); T. Ertl et al. (2020).

The last three columns provide the surface mass fractions of the most abundant elements, which are Helium $Y_{\text{surf}} \equiv X_{\text{surf}}(^4\text{He})$, Carbon, and Oxygen. These do not necessarily sum to 1 because of other isotopes present in our calculations, and are presumably sensitive to the wind mass-loss rates and mixing processes. Interestingly, most of our models still retain significant amount of helium at the surface (plus, some helium-rich material can appear in the core very late due to photodisintegration of iron-group nuclei).

M_{ZAMS} [$M_{\odot}$]	ω_{ZAMS} [ω_{crit}]	$\xi_{1.75}$	M_{Fe} [$M_{\odot}$]	M_4 [$M_{\odot}$]	μ_4 [$M_{\odot}/10^3\text{km}$]	Y_{surf}	$X_{\text{surf}}(^{12}\text{C})$	$X_{\text{surf}}(^{16}\text{O})$
30.00	0.55	0.592	1.41	1.70	0.173	0.32	0.16	0.48
30.00	0.94	0.395	3.14	1.56	0.114	0.26	0.16	0.51
32.00	0.55	0.544	2.23	1.96	0.134	0.31	0.21	0.42
32.00	0.70	0.616	1.76	1.81	0.133	0.31	0.15	0.46
32.00	0.84	0.468	2.21	1.58	0.143	0.46	0.09	0.34
34.00	0.60	0.597	2.10	1.88	0.133	0.66	0.04	0.22
34.00	0.65	0.650	1.33	1.95	0.179	0.37	0.14	0.44
34.00	0.74	0.648	1.45	2.05	0.166	0.24	0.17	0.54
34.00	0.84	0.651	1.76	1.90	0.132	0.26	0.16	0.53
34.00	0.94	0.652	1.46	1.91	0.153	0.40	0.14	0.41
34.00	0.99	0.545	2.11	1.85	0.127	0.73	0.04	0.17
36.00	0.60	0.651	2.10	1.90	0.138	0.26	0.16	0.50
36.00	0.65	0.542	3.39	1.76	0.186	0.28	0.16	0.49
36.00	0.70	0.683	2.11	1.92	0.144	0.25	0.17	0.50
36.00	0.74	0.631	1.49	2.08	0.180	0.82	0.03	0.10
36.00	0.79	0.551	2.20	1.99	0.134	0.75	0.04	0.15
36.00	0.84	0.640	1.31	2.14	0.193	0.29	0.17	0.51
36.00	0.89	0.651	1.42	2.11	0.180	0.25	0.17	0.53
36.00	0.94	0.615	2.13	1.94	0.134	0.29	0.16	0.47
36.00	0.99	0.530	2.12	1.91	0.131	0.52	0.07	0.30
38.00	0.60	0.696	2.18	2.12	0.180	0.76	0.05	0.14
38.00	0.70	0.559	2.36	1.77	0.148	0.46	0.08	0.34
38.00	0.74	0.536	2.45	1.69	0.150	0.61	0.07	0.23
38.00	0.79	0.661	1.66	2.16	0.229	0.70	0.06	0.18
38.00	0.84	0.642	1.41	2.07	0.197	0.70	0.06	0.17
38.00	0.89	0.604	1.54	1.74	0.150	0.53	0.10	0.30
38.00	0.94	0.640	1.42	1.98	0.177	0.67	0.07	0.19
38.00	0.99	0.575	2.16	1.99	0.121	0.48	0.09	0.32
40.00	0.55	0.588	1.48	1.81	0.204	0.28	0.17	0.50
40.00	0.60	0.656	1.62	2.10	0.177	0.85	0.06	0.07
40.00	0.65	0.637	2.76	1.81	0.158	0.83	0.07	0.08
40.00	0.70	0.637	2.23	1.94	0.135	0.45	0.10	0.33
40.00	0.79	0.474	2.18	1.94	0.114	0.27	0.12	0.45
40.00	0.84	0.541	2.16	1.80	0.146	0.55	0.10	0.27

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M_{ZAMS} [$M_{\odot}$]	ω_{ZAMS} [ω_{crit}]	$\xi_{1.75}$	M_{Fe} [$M_{\odot}$]	M_4 [$M_{\odot}$]	μ_4 [$M_{\odot}/10^3 \text{ km s}^{-1}$]	Y_{surf}	$X_{\text{surf}}(^{12}\text{C})$	$X_{\text{surf}}(^{16}\text{O})$
40.00	0.89	0.609	2.68	1.61	0.218	0.90	0.07	0.03
40.00	0.94	0.666	1.49	2.07	0.178	0.71	0.09	0.16
40.00	0.99	0.665	1.37	2.08	0.181	0.88	0.07	0.04
42.00	0.60	0.698	1.72	2.00	0.186	0.73	0.11	0.14
42.00	0.65	0.602	1.59	2.14	0.147	0.84	0.11	0.05
42.00	0.70	0.602	2.07	1.88	0.135	0.34	0.15	0.41
42.00	0.74	0.684	1.81	1.88	0.178	0.74	0.11	0.12
42.00	0.79	0.671	1.89	2.18	0.211	0.77	0.11	0.10
42.00	0.84	0.464	2.16	1.74	0.143	0.44	0.12	0.33
42.00	0.89	0.642	1.58	2.04	0.197	0.78	0.11	0.09
42.00	0.94	0.527	2.32	1.72	0.162	0.67	0.11	0.17
42.00	0.99	0.613	2.08	1.91	0.138	0.44	0.13	0.33
44.00	0.60	0.549	2.18	1.77	0.150	0.37	0.15	0.38
44.00	0.65	0.579	2.17	1.93	0.131	0.40	0.15	0.35
44.00	0.70	0.493	2.41	1.68	0.140	0.63	0.15	0.18
44.00	0.74	0.645	1.37	2.07	0.190	0.79	0.15	0.06
44.00	0.79	0.497	2.21	1.95	0.134	0.46	0.15	0.31
44.00	0.84	0.661	2.02	2.13	0.236	0.78	0.15	0.07
44.00	0.89	0.674	2.77	1.74	0.205	0.69	0.15	0.14
44.00	0.94	0.580	1.44	1.95	0.148	0.38	0.15	0.37
44.00	0.99	0.622	2.10	1.87	0.145	0.39	0.15	0.35
46.00	0.55	0.531	1.75	1.94	0.141	0.53	0.17	0.24
46.00	0.60	0.664	1.95	2.05	0.226	0.73	0.18	0.08
46.00	0.65	0.665	2.83	1.96	0.199	0.75	0.18	0.07
46.00	0.89	0.610	2.21	1.88	0.148	0.40	0.17	0.34
48.00	0.84	0.602	1.39	1.92	0.164	0.54	0.21	0.21
48.00	0.94	0.640	1.38	1.88	0.177	0.47	0.19	0.27
50.00	0.55	0.676	1.50	2.01	0.199	0.62	0.26	0.12
50.00	0.60	0.579	1.26	2.03	0.149	0.54	0.23	0.19
50.00	0.70	0.545	2.33	1.58	0.176	0.52	0.22	0.22
50.00	0.79	0.574	2.30	1.89	0.154	0.56	0.23	0.18
50.00	0.84	0.506	1.36	1.62	0.155	0.52	0.22	0.21
52.00	0.50	0.653	1.59	2.04	0.201	0.57	0.29	0.13
52.00	0.55	0.645	1.60	2.23	0.204	0.59	0.28	0.12
52.00	0.60	0.688	1.81	2.20	0.199	0.61	0.27	0.11
52.00	0.65	0.660	2.02	2.26	0.263	0.63	0.26	0.11
52.00	0.84	0.631	2.31	2.00	0.153	0.40	0.23	0.31
54.00	0.79	0.730	1.79	1.97	0.194	0.37	0.27	0.32
54.00	0.84	0.658	2.09	2.18	0.248	0.31	0.27	0.36
54.00	0.94	0.655	1.48	1.96	0.195	0.54	0.27	0.17
56.00	0.65	0.667	2.81	2.49	0.277	0.29	0.29	0.37
56.00	0.74	0.649	2.12	2.29	0.260	0.38	0.29	0.30
56.00	0.89	0.661	2.09	2.24	0.249	0.39	0.29	0.29
56.00	0.94	0.644	1.42	1.96	0.185	0.44	0.27	0.25
56.00	0.99	0.621	2.07	2.34	0.268	0.45	0.30	0.24
58.00	0.55	0.646	2.33	2.24	0.186	0.54	0.33	0.13
58.00	0.65	0.642	2.11	2.63	0.340	0.42	0.31	0.24

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M_{ZAMS} [$M_{\odot}$]	ω_{ZAMS} [ω_{crit}]	$\xi_{1.75}$	M_{Fe} [$M_{\odot}$]	M_4 [$M_{\odot}$]	μ_4 [$M_{\odot}/10^3 \text{ km s}^{-1}$]	Y_{surf}	$X_{\text{surf}}(^{12}\text{C})$	$X_{\text{surf}}(^{16}\text{O})$
58.00	0.74	0.666	2.01	2.26	0.268	0.42	0.32	0.25
58.00	0.94	0.656	2.51	2.33	0.248	0.39	0.30	0.28
58.00	0.99	0.679	1.61	2.14	0.229	0.56	0.31	0.12
60.00	0.50	0.626	2.01	2.51	0.293	0.36	0.32	0.28
60.00	0.60	0.604	2.27	2.54	0.294	0.48	0.33	0.18
60.00	0.94	0.602	2.15	2.59	0.305	0.52	0.33	0.15
62.00	0.50	0.603	2.17	2.64	0.297	0.42	0.32	0.22
62.00	0.60	0.658	2.04	2.40	0.282	0.39	0.33	0.25
62.00	0.70	0.633	2.04	2.38	0.276	0.38	0.33	0.27
64.00	0.74	0.607	2.12	2.41	0.278	0.38	0.33	0.26
64.00	0.84	0.589	2.43	2.76	0.352	0.37	0.33	0.27
66.00	0.60	0.627	2.07	2.61	0.343	0.45	0.36	0.18
66.00	0.94	0.609	2.15	2.43	0.315	0.38	0.33	0.26
68.00	0.65	0.598	2.17	2.58	0.318	0.40	0.35	0.23
70.00	0.60	0.606	2.14	2.60	0.294	0.45	0.37	0.17
72.00	0.74	0.594	2.18	2.61	0.311	0.37	0.35	0.25
72.00	0.79	0.661	2.04	2.58	0.307	0.49	0.38	0.13
72.00	0.89	0.599	2.29	2.57	0.313	0.46	0.38	0.15
74.00	0.60	0.644	2.14	2.64	0.309	0.48	0.39	0.13
74.00	0.94	0.657	2.12	2.31	0.274	0.49	0.38	0.13
76.00	0.55	0.644	2.46	2.32	0.253	0.47	0.39	0.13
76.00	0.74	0.645	1.49	1.98	0.235	0.48	0.39	0.12
78.00	0.74	0.646	2.02	2.58	0.350	0.44	0.38	0.17
78.00	0.79	0.645	1.99	2.23	0.238	0.44	0.37	0.17
80.00	0.50	0.669	2.10	2.32	0.273	0.48	0.40	0.12
82.00	0.50	0.603	2.26	2.62	0.361	0.45	0.39	0.15
84.00	0.55	0.604	2.37	2.87	0.385	0.47	0.40	0.12
84.00	0.60	0.593	2.25	2.68	0.369	0.34	0.35	0.27
84.00	0.70	0.590	2.40	2.75	0.386	0.36	0.36	0.25
84.00	0.74	0.605	2.27	2.72	0.378	0.48	0.40	0.12
88.00	0.84	0.642	2.64	2.38	0.266	0.48	0.40	0.12
96.00	0.70	0.587	2.28	2.66	0.352	0.48	0.41	0.11

Table 1. Explodability metrics for our CHE models, and final surface composition. $\xi_{1.75}$ is the compactness parameter (E. O’Connor & C. D. Ott 2011) calculated at mass coordinate $\mathcal{M} = 1.75 M_{\odot}$ (A. Burrows et al. 2024), the iron core mass M_{Fe} , $M_4 \equiv \max(m(s < 4 k_B N_A))$ and $\mu_4 = dm/dr(m = M_4)$ (T. Ertl et al. 2016). The last three columns are the final surface mass fractions of helium $Y_{\text{surf}} \equiv X_{\text{surf}}(^4\text{He})$, carbon, and oxygen. These do not necessarily sum to 1 because of other isotopes present in our calculations.

B. DESCRIPTION OF THE DATA PRODUCTS

We share the stellar models described in this paper at doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.14286306, to provide initial conditions for stellar explosion studies. In the repository, `template.tar.xz` contains the input files for our MESA simulations, designed for version `r24.03.1`.

This includes a customized `rn` script that tries to use the `mail` command-line utility to send the last MESA `pgstar` output and the last lines of the terminal output to the user. This requires modifying the email address, and may not work depending on the setup of `mail` on the machine running the models. Failure to send the

email notification will not affect the MESA calculations in any way.

The numerical results are in `grid.tar`, which contains a separate tarball for each star, labeled as `<M>_rot<0>.tar.xz` where `<M>` is the ZAMS mass in $M_{\odot}$ with one decimal digit, and `<0>` is the initial value of $\omega_{\text{ZAMS}}/\omega_{\text{crit}}$ with two decimal digits. We only include the models reaching successfully the onset of core-collapse ($v_{\text{infall}} \lesssim 300 \text{ km s}^{-1}$) and pass our visual inspection (cf. Fig. 1).

Each `<M>_rot<0>.tar.xz` provides a MESA work directory containing the input files for that specific model, the full terminal output of the run (`output.txt`), a few plots generated on-the-fly by MESA `pgstar` inside the subfolder `png`, the `history.data` file and selected `profile*.data` in the subfolder `LOGS`. All profiles at the onset of core collapse are named `CHE_single_core_collapse.data`, we also provide profiles and MESA `*.mod` files for the first time the temperature in the star exceeds $\log_{10}(T/\text{[K]}) = 8.95$ (`CHE_logT895.mod`), core Oxygen depletion (`O_depl.mod`, defined as the first timestep when the central mass fractions $X_c(^{16}\text{O}) < 0.1$ and $X_c(^{12}\text{C})$ and $X_c(^4\text{He})$ are both < 0.001 and $X_c(^1\text{H}) < 0.5$) and core Silicon depletion (`Si_depl.mod`, defined as the first timestep when the central mass fractions $X_c(^{28}\text{Si}), X_c(^{16}\text{O}), X_c(^{12}\text{C}) < 5 \times 10^{-3}$ and $X_c(^4\text{He}) < 0.2$ and $X_c(^1\text{H}) < 0.5$). These conditions conservatively and consistently define the moment of core Oxygen and Silicon core depletion across the grid with 128 isotopes.

Profiles and/or `*.mod` files can be used to initialize multi-dimensional simulations at times earlier than the onset of core collapse, for example to study pre-collapse shell mergers and/or initializing self-consistent (non-MLT) convection velocity profiles (e.g., B. Côté et al. 2020; N. Yadav et al. 2020; C. E. Fields 2022; J. Issa & F. Herwig 2025; A. Griffiths et al. 2026; J. Issa et al. 2026)

Finally, `scripts.tar.xz` contains the python scripts used in the analysis of our grid, including an `environment.yml` file, to ensure the full reproducibility of our results ■ **finalize figures, upload to zenodo, make public** ■.